

WHAT THE PHASES OF YOUR CYCLE MEAN?

The menstrual cycle is the monthly process the body goes through to prepare for a possible pregnancy. It begins on the first day of a period and ends on the day before the next period starts.

For many people, the average menstrual cycle lasts about 28 days, but cycles ranging from 21 to 35 days are considered normal. Most periods last between three and seven days.

Hormones released by the brain and ovaries control the menstrual cycle. These hormones cause changes in the uterus and ovaries that follow a repeating pattern each month.

The Main Phases of the Cycle

Phase 1: Menstrual Phase

- Begins on day one of the cycle
- The lining of the uterus sheds and leaves the body through bleeding
- Most people bleed for three to seven days

Common symptoms may include:

- Cramping
- Fatigue
- Mood changes
- Bloating
- Headaches

Phase 2: Follicular Phase

- Begins on the same day as the period and continues until ovulation
- Estrogen rises and causes the uterine lining to grow again
- Follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH) signals the ovaries to develop follicles
- Usually, one follicle becomes dominant and develops into a mature egg

Phase 3: Ovulation

Ovulation usually occurs around the middle of the menstrual cycle. In a 28-day cycle, this is typically around day 14.

A hormone called luteinizing hormone (LH) triggers the ovary to release a mature egg. The egg then travels through the fallopian tube toward the uterus. This is the time when a person is most likely to become pregnant if sperm fertilizes the egg.

The egg survives for about 24 hours after ovulation.

Phase 4: Luteal Phase

The luteal phase begins after ovulation and lasts until the next period starts.

During this phase:

- Progesterone rises to prepare the uterus for possible pregnancy
- The uterine lining remains thick to support implantation
- If fertilization does not happen, hormone levels fall
- The lining breaks down and sheds, starting the next period

Why Understanding Your Cycle Matters

Understanding the phases of your menstrual cycle can help you:

- Recognize patterns in your body
- Track ovulation and fertility
- Identify irregular periods
- Monitor changes in menstrual health

Tracking your cycle can also help healthcare providers understand what is normal for your body.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

*Educational content informed by Cleveland Clinic. (2022). Menstrual Cycle.
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. Menstruation in Girls and Adolescents: Using the Menstrual Cycle as a Vital Sign.
National Health Service. Periods and fertility in the menstrual cycle.*